B2 Speaking

Agreeing and disagreeing politely

Share your view in discussions and exams: agree strongly, agree in part, or disagree without sounding rude.

In discussions, speaking exams and meetings you need to react to other people's ideas. Strong disagreement is fine in English if you soften it and give a reason.

Function	Phrases
Strong agreement	*Absolutely. I couldn't agree more. That's exactly what I think.*
Partial agreement	*I see what you mean, but... That's true to some extent, however...*
Polite disagreement	*I'm not sure I agree. I see it a bit differently. I take your point, but...*
Asking for an opinion	*What do you think? How do you feel about...? Would you agree that...?*
Giving a reason	*The main reason is... For example,... That's why I think...*

Agree before you disagree. Starting with something you accept (*That's a fair point, but...*) makes the other person more ready to listen.

Common mistakes. *I am agree* is wrong: say *I agree*. And avoid a flat *You are wrong*; say *I'm not sure that's right* or *I see it differently*.

Practice

1. Correct the mistake: I am agree with you.
2. Make polite: You're wrong about the price.
3. Agree strongly with: "We should learn English every day."
4. Agree in part with: "Social media is bad for teenagers."
5. Ask a classmate for their opinion about online learning.

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1. I agree with you.
2. I'm not sure that's the right price. / I think the price might be different.
3. Absolutely, I couldn't agree more.
4. That's true to some extent, but it can also help them stay in touch with friends. (any partial agreement + reason)
5. What do you think about online learning? / How do you feel about online learning?